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Remembering Guruvayur Dorai and his journey as a mridangist p2

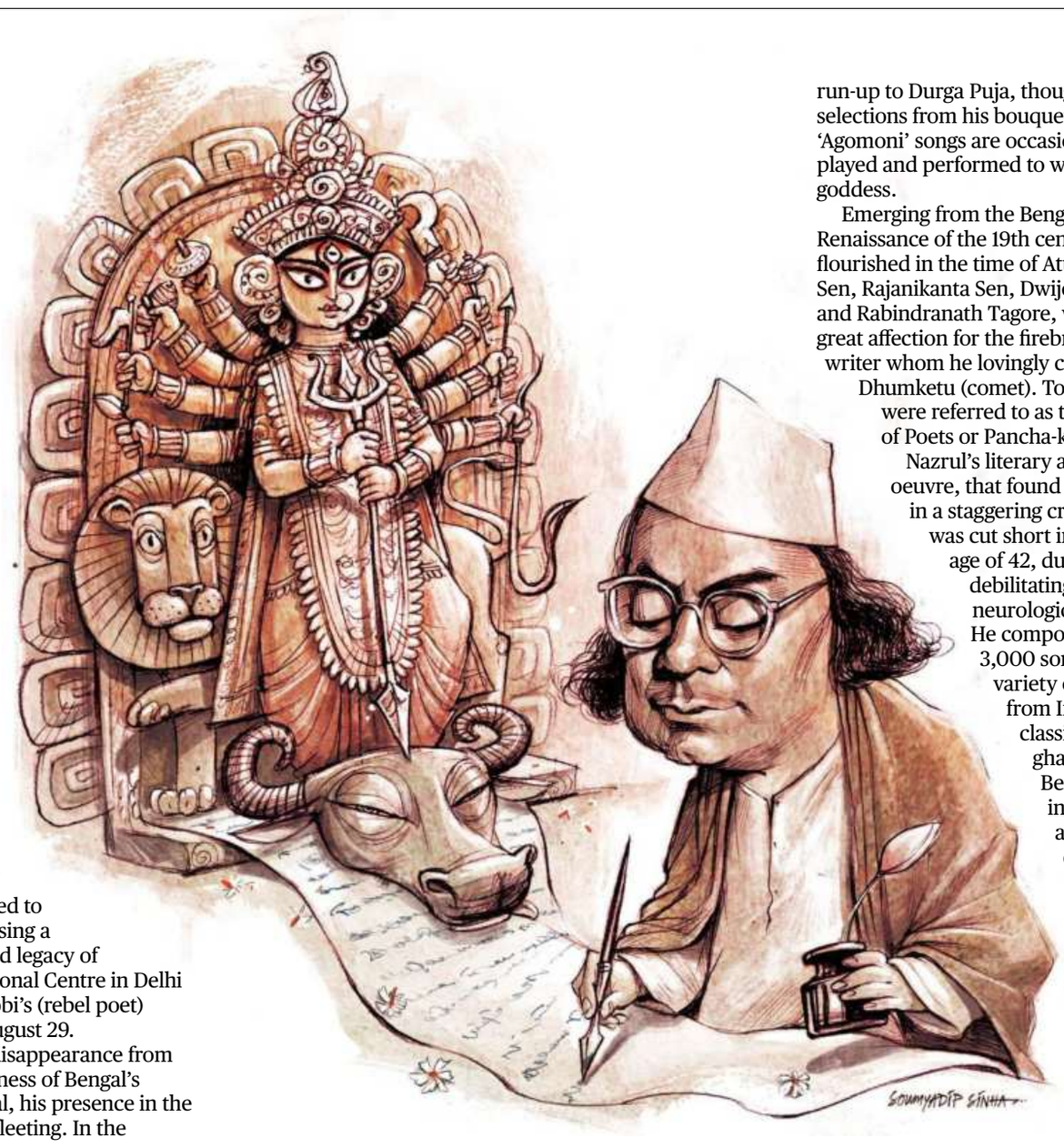
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SONGS OF NAVARATRI
When kolu dolls take over homes, the devotional playlist falls into place too p4

Durga's inclusive bard

Poet Kazi Nazrul Islam's Agomoni songs, part of the vast canon of Nazrulgeeti, welcome the deity each autumn while conveying powerful social and cultural messages that transcend devotion



Shantanu Datta

Early this year in Kolkata, while examining India's pluralism and multiculturalism, a panel of elite speakers mentioned several literary and cultural icons of Bengal, including Rabindranath Tagore and Satyajit Ray. But one name – Kazi Nazrul Islam – was curiously missing from the list.

Political scientist and author, Mujibur Rahman, who was in attendance took note of this omission and decided to make amends by organising a discussion on the life and legacy of Nazrul at India International Centre in Delhi ahead of the 'Bidrohi Kobi's (rebel poet) death anniversary on August 29.

Nazrul's (1899-1976) disappearance from the collective consciousness of Bengal's intelligentsia is near total, his presence in the people's sphere at best fleeting. In the run-up to Durga Puja, though, selections from his bouquet of 'Agomoni' songs are occasionally played and performed to welcome the goddess.

Emerging from the Bengal Renaissance of the 19th century, Nazrul flourished in the time of Atul Prasad Sen, Rajanikanta Sen, Dwijendralal Roy and Rabindranath Tagore, who had great affection for the firebrand young writer whom he lovingly called Dhumketu (comet). Together, they were referred to as the Pentagon of Poets or Pancha-kobi.

Nazrul's literary and musical oeuvre, that found expression in a staggering creative span, was cut short in 1942 at the age of 42, due to a debilitating neurological disorder. He composed over 3,000 songs in a variety of genres – from Indian classical to ghazals – in Bengali. A stint in the British army exposed him to Persian literature, its influences finding their way into his songs. He discovered God in all faiths, composing Islamic songs and some of the most moving kirtans invoking goddess Kali and Durga. He was a passionate advocate of amity, countering communal tensions with songs of unity: "On the same branch blossom twin buds Hindu and Muslim (Hindu-Musalman duti bhai bharater dui ankhi-tara)'.

In his Agomoni (welcome) songs, Nazrul personifies Maa Durga often addressed as Uma. She is coming home to her mother. It is a celebration. Yet, in these portrayals of innocent indulgences, Nazrul never lost sight of her greater purpose. As Mahisasurmordini, the demon slayer, she is victorious with the poet framing her arrival within the context of personal demons that propel us to choose hate over love, dogma over humanity and falsehoods over truths.

"Durga, who has become our child Uma, is, therefore, also instilling in us a sense of confidence," explains author-mentor Devajit Bandopadhyay.

"She is the embodiment of courage to fight the demon, Mahisasur, who in the realm of our day-to-day life, represents social evils we turn a blind eye to," says Devajit, who is also a singer and musicologist. His untiring research initiatives have unearthed a treasure trove of unpublished songs in the overarching canon of Nazrulgeeti.

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Mythical grandeur From 'Endaro Mahanubhavulu'. PHOTOS: R. RAGU & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A kriti in choreography

Anita Guha's new work 'Endaro Mahanubhavulu' is inspired by Tyagaraja's timeless Pancharatna composition

V.V. Ramani

The vast diversity of art, thought and literature that flourishes in India is a rich source of inspiration for creative minds. Acknowledging the contributions of innumerable poets, musicians and spiritual leaders, Tyagaraja says: 'Andhariki Vandhanamu' (I offer my obeisance to all) in his popular Sri raga Pancharatna kriti, 'Endaro mahanubhavulu'. As a tribute to the saint-composer, his unwavering devotion to Rama and his spirit of total surrender, scholar Dushyanth Sridhar has conceptualised and scripted a Natya Nadakam titled after this timeless kriti.

Anita Guha, the founder of Bharatanjali, has choreographed the production to the musical score by Rajkumar Bharathi with sound design by Sai Shravanam.

The narrative, presented in seven segments, opened with the story of Doddacharya of Cholasighapura. His steadfast devotion to Varadaraja moved the deity to grant him darshan of the temple processions whenever he was unable to travel and witness the festivities in person. The opening sequences, depicting the Sibika, Simha and Ashva vahanas, were vibrant and evoked a festive spirit. A succession of stories followed: Adi Shankaracharya's *Kanakadhara Stotram*; Vedanta Desikar's *Sri Stuti*, which invoked goddess Lakshmi to bestow prosperity; and Muthuswami Dikshitar's 'Anandamritakarshini', a hymn to goddess Bhavani – that is believed to have brought rain to a parched land. Together, these episodes underscored the power of unwavering devotion to the divine.

Anecdotes and compositions with a range of poet-saints and literary figures, from the lesser-known Telugu poet Bommera Pothana to Jayadeva, Kamban, Andal, Meerabai, Bhadrachala Ramadasu, Purandaradasa and Sant Tukaram, were interwoven with verses from sacred texts, shlokas and the Puranas to depict the concept of dharma.

Over the years, Anita Guha has evolved a choreographic formula that combines a wide range of movement patterns and striking visual elements that would appeal to a wider audience. This production adhered to that familiar format, featuring an ensemble of 53 well-trained dancers and a choreography with no dull moments helped sustain the momentum throughout. Fast-paced *nritta* sequences, vibrant costumes, elaborate headgear and makeup, an amazing LED backdrop,



colourful lighting and an engaging musical score collectively enhanced the production's appeal.

While Bharatanatyam formed the core of the presentation, Anita Guha also incorporated elements from other dance forms to enrich the narrative. For instance, Kuchipudi's *yavanika* tradition, based on verses from Krishnadevaraya's *Amuktamalyada*, was woven into the episode on Andal drawn from the *Nachiyar Tirumozhi*. The segment on Meerabai included movements from the Rajasthani dance form *Ghoomar*, complemented by colourful costumes, while *Kottichedam*, a distinctive dance style associated with Mohiniyattam, was employed to show the durbar of a Chera king.

The *Hanuman Chalisa*, which has become something of a staple in dance productions of late, was used not only to celebrate Hanuman's strength and devotion but also to introduce *hasya rasa* through the playful antics of the monkey brigade.

The energy levels rose further with the depiction of *Varkari seva*, the singing of abhangs by marching devotees and the collective chanting of "Panduranga Vittala", gradually building the production to a crescendo.

Among the production's most significant moments were its captivating visuals, particularly the image of Lakshmi emerging from the lotus, depicted through a choreographed formation of dancers, surrounded by the images of Adi Shankarar and Vedanta Desikar. The lotus pond imagery on the screen further enriched the sequence. Equally impressive was the dramatic *Gajendra moksham*, where Vishnu's swirling chakra vanquishes the crocodile, conveyed through the circular movements of the dancers. The careful attention to detail in Garuda's costume and makeup, as well as the props, including the five-headed snake, also merits special mention.

The continuous flurry of activity kept the audience constantly engaged. Yet some of the episodes, rich in emotions, could have been dealt with in detail and in an unhurried manner, allowing the *rasanubhava* of bhakti to unfold expansively.

The large ensemble of dancers performed admirably, marked by neat entries and exits, well-coordinated movements and a clear understanding of the characterisation.

The lighting design by Murugan and Nambu Kumar enhanced the visual narrative. The thoughtful props were by 'Kumar Stage' Shanmugam while Gnana Chandra's screen visuals stood out for their restrained palette.

Can you guess the raga?

The Music Academy's Raga Identification competition is back. It will be held on October 24

For a classical musician, delving into the depths of a raga is a sublime experience born of years of learning and rigorous sadhana. For the rasika, the joy lies in listening, connecting with the music, and recognising the raga being presented. Indeed, one of the most rewarding aspects of attending a concert is identifying a raga as it unfolds.

It was this shared joy of musical discovery that inspired R.T. Chari to conceive the Raga Identification competition.

Jointly organised by The Music Academy, TAG Corporation, and Ramu Endowments, the Raga Identification Competition is a unique initiative created exclusively for rasikas. Unlike most music competitions, it is not aimed at performing artistes or students of music, but at the lay listener who delights in recognising ragas from brief audio excerpts.

The competition was conceived and designed by R.T. Chari of the TAG Group of Companies. Having faced the challenge of identifying ragas himself, Chari set out to make the process easier and more engaging for fellow rasikas. What began with the distribution of audio recordings that captured the essence of different ragas evolved into a larger effort to educate and nurture informed listening. The competition is one of the many ways in which that vision continues to find expression.

Over the years, several distinguished musicians have guided participants on the art of raga identification. Among the resource persons who have lent their expertise to the competition are R.S. Jayalakshmi, Sriram Parasuram, Neyveli Santhanagopalan, and Baby Sreeram.

This year, the competition will conclude with a talk by Baby Sreeram titled *Raga Bhava*, which explores the myriad shades and emotional nuances of a raga.

The competition was conducted from its inception by Sumathi Krishnan. The initiative is now being spearheaded by Preeti Sethuraman, an alumna of the Advanced School of Carnatic Music.

Audio excerpts for the competition are drawn from the vast collection of concert recordings preserved in the Music Academy-TAG Archives, one of the country's valuable repositories of Carnatic music.

The competition will be held at The Music Academy on October 24 at 10 a.m. Participants are required to report by 9 a.m. It is open only to individual participants; team entries are not permitted.

There is no age limit. However, performing musicians and music students are not eligible to participate. Past first-prize winners are also not eligible to re-enter. Audio clips will be played for raga identification, and participants may occasionally be asked to identify the singer as well.

To register, participants may send an email to rajagopalk@tagcorporation.net. For more details, call 98843 20292. The last date for registration is October 19.

Thematic concert

Sarvani Sangeetha Sabha Trust's Navaratri utsav will feature Shruti Bhat's thematic vocal concert on October 18, 6.15 p.m. at Ragasudha Hall, Mylapore. She will be accompanied by Harita Narayanan (violin) and A. Rohith (mridangam).

Dance festival

Rasika Ranjani Sabha Foundation presents a specially curated dance series, 'The Grand Nrtyotsav', between October 19 and 30 at Sundareswarar Hall, Mylapore. Two performances by up-and-coming dancers (5 p.m. and 6.45 p.m.) will take place on each day of the festival.
Schedule: October 19: Pravarthika Balaji and B. Padmapriya. October 20: Anjannaa Ashok and Mrudula Ramanujan. October 21: Saakshi Mohan and Shreya Suresh. October 24: Shraddha Sridhar and R. Shruti Umaiyaal. October 26: Saheli Sen and Sahana Selvaganesh. October 27: Swetha Swaminathan and Shreyas Nair. October 28: Chinmayee Devarayan and Priyanjali Rao. October 29: S. Sathwika Reddy (Kuchipudi) and Divya Menon. October 30: Annapurani Karthikeyan and Meghana Krishnan.

A life in rhythm

Rooted in the Pudukkottai bani yet distinctly original, the mridangam exponent enriched every concert and nurtured generations of musicians



K. Arun Prakash

Vidwan Guruvayur Dorai, affectionately known as Dorai *mama*, was not only an exponent of the mridangam but also a musician with a profound understanding of the *ruchi* of Carnatic music.His accompaniment was so deeply musical that, in many concerts, it was difficult to distinguish the mridangam from the music itself. His incredible left-right balance on the instrument, masterful use of *chapus* and *arai chapus*, flowing *sarvalaghus*, and resonant *gumkis*, all delivered at precisely the right moments, made listening to him a truly delightful experience for all of us.

I have always believed that only a true rasika can become a true musician. In that sense, Dorai *mama* was as exceptional a rasika as he was a musician. While accompanying, he could often be seen appreciating the raga alapanas, niraval and swara patterns, thereby inspiring the musicians on stage. Such moments revealed not only his innate sensitivity to music but also his deep appreciation of fellow musicians and their artistry. They reflected both his profound musicality and his generous spirit.

Dorai *mama* was deeply inspired by the Pudukkottai bani of percussion and cherished the dream of learning from the legendary Palani Subramania Pillai. By the time Palani *anna* accepted him as his disciple, he had already been accompanying several leading musicians in concerts.

Although Dorai *mama* remained firmly rooted in the Pudukkottai bani, he developed his own distinctive ideas and musical sensibilities, allowing his individuality to flourish beautifully within the tradition.

His profound *raga gnana* and deep understanding of the Carnatic sound were evident in every performance. He was an integral part of the musical expression, responding diligently to every nuance and enriching the overall concert experience.

Even his tani avartanams were imbued with musicality. Whether presenting intricate korvais or developing a kuraippu, he always seemed to have a well-conceived vision. His rhythmic phrases were carefully crafted, ensuring that technical brilliance went hand in hand with musicality and aesthetic fulfilment.

All these came naturally to Dorai *mama* because he was also an accomplished vocalist who had presented full-fledged vocal concerts. His versatility as a performer, combined with his deep understanding of the art form, made him a complete musician.

Dorai m*ama* inspired generations of musicians, not just percussionists but artistes across the Carnatic music fraternity. He trained innumerable students, imparting not only the intricacies of mridangam playing but also values such as discipline, humility, and wisdom. Through the many students he nurtured, his influence will remain an enduring presence in Carnatic music.

The writer is a senior mridangam artiste.



Twirl 'n' slay Experimenting to lend a new dimension to garba fashion PHOTOS: GETTY IMAGES

Glam up for garba

Quirky chaniya-cholis, statement accessories, glares, tattoos and edgy nail art: This Navaratri, festive fashion turns maximalist

Shailaja Tripathi

A choli from Surat, a chaniya from Vadodara, Navaratri glares from an online brand, metal handcuffs and a quirky musafir ring from an Instagram seller. Boxes arrive at my doorstep one after the other. I am already besotted with Navaratri bindis and tattoos, while hair accessories, *haathphool* and more still sit in my shopping cart. This festive season, I am going all out with the bling.

Putting together an outfit for garba is no longer just about finding a colourful chaniya-choli. There are nine nights and nine looks for enthusiasts. The preparations begin months in advance – with fabric, jewellery, makeup and accessories – planned well before the first beat of the dhol. For some, it is literally a year-round exercise.

People are experimenting with fabrics, designs and accessories, bringing new dimensions to garba fashion. For Rutvij Mistry, a queer professor in the Fine Arts Department at Maharaja Sayajirao University in Vadodara and a passionate garba dancer, fashion is an expression that transcends gender. Rutvij has been experimenting with layered costumes since 2014. The ensembles often feature two or three flared skirts, sometimes paired with a jacket, bringing together different fabrics and textures. For Rutvij, the joy lies as much in the layers as in the movement. "The heavier the costume, the more I enjoy dancing," says Rutvij with a laugh.

For those who want to dance in style, preparations for the next Navaratri begin almost as soon as the current one ends. Finding the right fabrics and designs, and coordinating with the people who make the outfits, can be time-consuming. The costumes can be used for three to four years, but people keep finding new ways to restyle them.

A statement-making garba look is never complete without accessories that add an extra touch of festive glamour. For women, accessorising is a head-to-toe affair, with choices spanning the quirky and contemporary to the timeless charm of old-world elegance. For men, too, the variety is mind-boggling, beginning with the pagdi, a carefully considered element of the ensemble. They often match it with the outfit to elevate the look. "There is also cause behind this effort – supporting craftspeople," says Rutvij, who regularly visits textile fairs or searches online for handlooms and handmade accessories.

Enterprising sellers display chaniya choli sets, showcasing even the minutest details, take orders and ship outfits to customers across borders. Online shopping has made it easier for people living outside Gujarat to find the perfect garba attire.

Haathphool, ear cuffs, oversized rings, metal hand cuffs and decorative phone slings are also making their way into the festive wardrobe. Hair accessories such as embellished parandis, colourful scrunchies, hair bows, floral pieces and decorated hair chains are in this season. The idea is to make every detail complement the outfit, whether the overall mood is traditional or bohemian.



Tattoos, too, have become part of the festive look. Deepika Padukone's neck tattoo in Sanjay Leela Bhansali's 'Goliyon Ki Raasleela Ram-Leela' remains a major inspiration for those looking to stand out. There are ample brands that offer Navaratri-themed designs inspired by rangoli, traditional motifs and garba movements, including semi-permanent options.

Who can forget the nails? Social media is flooded with edgy Navaratri nail art, with decorative elements such as tiiny ghungroos threaded through a loop in nail extensions.

Not everyone follows garba fashion trends. Radhika Raje Gaekwad, a member of Vadodara's erstwhile royal family who helms the Lukshmi Vilas Palace Heritage Garba, is keen to preserve the form of garba she knows well.

She recalls the intimate neighbourhood gatherings known as sheri garba, where people came together to sing, dance and pray in nooks and corners across Gujarat. As cities have grown, large venues, DJs, Bollywood tracks and elaborate stage productions have become part of the wider Navaratri scene.

According to Radhika, the traditional form continues to hold its ground in Vadodara. The music is sung live, without Bollywood tracks, and familiar steps such as Teen Taali and Dodhiyu remain central. The movements are simple enough for large groups to follow.

For Radhika, that sense of community is also a reason to use the festival as a platform for inclusion. For her, preserving garba is not limited to keeping its music and movements alive. By making space for people across genders and identities, she hopes to ensure that this centuries-old tradition remains relevant to a changing society.

Durga's inclusive bard



CONTINUED FROM
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Consider the Agomoni song, 'Joy Durga, Janani, Dao Shakti' (Hail Durga, mother, give us strength), which begins with an invocation to the goddess and continues as a prayer seeking self-belief and unfiltered knowledge. The poet pleads for the strength that comes from love and conviction and asks the goddess for help, and protective gear (kavach), so that we do not shy away from this fight to embrace truth and humanity.

In 'Ebar nabin mantra' (This time, Mother, the young will pray at your unveiling), Nazrul targets divisive social customs. Rejecting class hierarchies and demolishing barriers of prejudice, he says, the youth from all over will join the welcoming of the goddess. In 'Chinmoyee roop dhore aye', he exhorts the goddess to return in person, as offerings to the idol of her likeness hasn't quite freed us from our demons. Annapurna Ma calls upon us to light lamps of freedom amid the sounding of conch shells to herald Durga's arrival in our "impoverished" land rendered so by colonial subjugation.

At the very core, Nazrul the poet is the embodiment of Hindu-Muslim unity. As a life-long rebel, he left behind a body of work in literature and music that's fearless in its construct against oppression, speaking out against the colonial powers of the past and the continuing injustices of today. If Bengal is suffering from intellectual amnesia, neighbouring Bangladesh, where he was declared as the National Poet, is abandoning past moorings. Culture vultures are even altering lyrics of Nazrul's songs to replace markers of faith, thereby striking at his syncretic core. Agomoni or not, goddess Durga, worshipped and celebrated across our shared borders, has her divine task cut out. So has 'Bidrohi Kobi'.







Framed in grace (Clockwise from left) Stills from Uday Shankar's *Kalpana; Ancestral Shadows*; and dancer Surupa Sen. PHOTOS: THE HINDU ARCHIVES & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Dance through a lens

The LURU Screendance Festival spotlighted the evolving relationship between the artiste and the camera

Shilpa Anandraj
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Dance has always been among India's most visible art forms. Yet for all its richness, much of its history remains poorly documented. Performances disappear once the curtain falls, and generations of work survive through memory, oral histories and scattered photographs rather than a sustained visual archive.

The West, meanwhile, has a longer history of documenting ballet and modern dance through films. But filming dance is not simply about recording what happens on stage. The moment movement enters the frame, the camera, editing, sound and perspective begin to reshape it. The camera neither merely preserves dance nor is a passive observer; it changes the way dance can be seen, remembered and understood.

This was the premise behind the LURU Screendance Festival, launched by Bengaluru-based dancer-choreographer and dance film director Vishwakiran Nambi. The pilot edition, presented by the Vishwakiran Nambi Dance Company in collaboration with Choreoscope Barcelona Dance Films Festival, brought together dance films from India and across the world.

For Vishwakiran, the festival was a response to what he saw as a fundamental weakness in India's relationship with its own dance history. "India is predominantly known for bad documentation," he said. However, Uday Shankar's *Kalpana*, made in 1948, is an exception. It was conceived not simply as a record of dance but as a work in which movement, cinema, music, design and narrative could exist together. Decades later, the film was restored through Martin Scorsese's World Cinema Project. It is this history – and the gap between what India once attempted and what it has failed to sustain – that gives LURU its larger relevance.

The festival received 108 submissions from 30 countries, with 13 short dance films screened at Suchitra Film Society. The films varied widely in their understanding of movement and in the relationship they established between the dancer and the camera.

The Flight of the Shawl, directed by Jaime Dezcallar and featuring flamenco dancer Manuel Linan, was visually striking. Dezcallar's *Spanish Chica* won the LURU Best Music Video Award, while Lino Eckenstein's *The Dust of My Concrete Child - Portrait 6: Risk & Balance* won the Best Cinematography Award and his *The Dust of My Concrete Child - Portrait 2: Viscousness & Vulnerability* received the Best Choreography Award. India's Sumedha Bhattacharyya's film, *Monalisa* and Canada's *In My Room*, by Kaitlyn Seibold, won the Best Screendance Film awards.

But does a cinematographer need to understand dance to film it effectively? Dezcallar challenged that assumption. Coming from the world of advertising rather than dance, he said his approach was driven by his passion for movement rather than formal dance training.

"I see the choreography and decide where the most interesting angle is. Sometimes I let dancers leave the frame, and sometimes I move with them. It depends on the feeling I want to express," he said. That difference in approach points to one of Screendance's central questions: should the camera understand dance from within, or can an outsider's eye reveal something the dancer and choreographer may not see?



Dancer, choreographer and scholar Uttara Asha Coorlawala, who has written extensively on Indian dance and its histories, feels one doesn't have to understand dance, they just have to feel it.

For LURU's debut edition, Vishwakiran deliberately kept the theme open-ended. The festival accepted films dealing with dance, music and movement, while future editions, he said, would focus more specifically on dance films and introduce themes.

Social media has trivialised dance into catchy loops and background noise, turning movement into memes. At the same time, it has introduced audiences to global work they might never otherwise encounter. Screendance sits at this crossroads – between democratisation and dilution, said Nambi, who has also directed the dance film *The Kitchen* and choreographed for Telugu, Kannada and Tamil films.

"Dance films represent a very specific kind of filmmaking that has tremendous potential," said Surupa Sen, artistic director of Nrityagram. During the pandemic, she found that filming could bring attention to details that were almost impossible to see in a live performance. "A kathak improvisation or an Odissi solo can be streamed, studied and revisited by audiences far beyond the space in which it was originally performed," shared Surupa, who was asked by the New York Public Library to document her work. "It will then be available for people to access so they can understand how each choreographer works and thinks."

Uttara also spoke about the freedom that the screen offers. "Screen dance also opens up a personal space, where what one sees is what one presents and what one feels is what one wants everyone to feel. There is no hesitation about clipping and cutting. *Kalpana* itself went through three rounds of editing, and each version changed the narrative. That shows how editing can reshape meaning," she said.

Going back to *Kalpana*, the making of which also reveals the longstanding struggle of artistes with patronage and resources.

Urmimala Sarkar Munsi, a social anthropologist, dance scholar, dancer and choreographer who has extensively researched Uday Shankar and his work, said: "The film starts with the dancer trying to sell his story to a producer who asks for something for the box office. Seventy years later, it's the same story. Fantastic ideas dilute into something ordinary because there is no investor. What began as an act of creation also became an act of documentation. The film did not succeed at the box office, but remains seminal."

For Nambi, this is the very reason why *Kalpana* remains such an important reference point and described screen dance as "a triadic conversation among camera, dance and space. *Kalpana* still stands the test of time – its factory choreography remains fresh, abstract and modern even today. You can cut and paste that into 2026 and it'll still work."

In India, he pointed out, no comparable attempt has followed. "I've pitched contemporary dance features to producers, but they back out. They think it's too artistic, not for the common man. Even Balasaraswati needed Satyajit Ray to document her work."

Surupa feels documentation also requires institutional commitment. "On a national level, the amount of investment that must be made, not just for the present but for the future, is hugely lacking," she said. Yet, Surupa remains hopeful about what documentation can achieve.

The problem, then, is not merely the absence of films. It is the absence of a sustained archival culture around dance – one that records not just performances, but the thinking, process and vocabulary behind them.

LURU, therefore, is evolving as a space where boundaries among dance, cinema and documentation continue to blur.



A golu display at *The Hindu* office. PHOTO: BIJOY GHOSH

What's your favourite kolu song?

From timeless kritis to popular hymns, here's your Navaratri playlist

T.R. Sudha
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It's that time of the year when colourful kolu dolls adorn homes, a variety of *sundals* is prepared and women bring out their finest silks. But what are festivities without music? As you make your kolu rounds, visit friends and family, and welcome guests into your home this Navaratri, you would want songs and chants to fill the air.

From Muthuswami Dikshitar's timeless Navavarana kritis, a set of nine compositions in praise of goddess Kamalamba, to Syama Sastri's evocative Swarajatis dedicated to goddess Kamakshi, there is no dearth of music associated with the festival. Beyond these celebrated works, several Carnatic kritis, Tamil devotional songs and Sanskrit shlokas have become Navaratri staples over the years. Here's a devotional playlist to accompany your celebrations.

- **Bhagyada lakshmi baaramma** (Purandaradasar, Madhyamavati)
- **Mahalakshmi jagan matha** (Papanasam Sivan, Sankarabharanam)
- **Sri chakra raja simhasaneswari** (Ragamalika)
- **Naanoru vilaiyattu bommaiya** (Papanasam Sivan, Navarasa Kanada)
- **Saraswathi namostuthe** (GNB, Saraswathi & & Muthuswami Dikshitar, Arabhi)
- **Mamavathu Sri Saraswati** (Mysore Vasudevachar, Hindolam)
- **Janani ninnuvina** (Subbaraya Sastri, Ritigowla)
- **Sarojadala netri** (Syama Sastri, Sankarabharanam)
- **Himadri suthe pahimam** (Syama Sastri, Kalyani).

Besides these kritis, the nine days also resonate with the chanting of shlokas dedicated to different forms of Shakti – Durga, Lakshmi and Saraswathi. They include Mahishasura Mardini Stotram (Durga); Kanakadhara Stotram and Mahalakshmi Ashtakam (Lakshmi) and Saraswathi Namasthubyam and Yakundhedhu (Saraswathi). Not to miss the Tamil hymn 'Sakala kala valli malai', in praise of Saraswathi and 'Mangala roopini madhiani' dedicated to Kamakshi. A few Tamil devotional songs including 'Jaya jaya devi durga devi saranam' and 'Chinna chiru penn pole' are also popular choices.

The resonant chants of *Lalitha Sahasranamam* also add to the festive spirit.

A desert musical safari

As Jodhpur RIFF turns 20 at the historic Mehrangarh Fort, its commitment to promoting folk music remains central to its legacy



Team Friday Review

For 20 years, Jodhpur RIFF has brought roots musicians from Rajasthan, India and across the world together at Mehrangarh Fort. This year, from October 22 to 26, the festival returns for its 20th edition, once again timed to Sharad Purnima.

Held under the aegis of the Mehrangarh Museum Trust, the festival brings together musicians from six continents and more than a dozen countries including Colombia, Chile, Cabo Verde, Poland, Scotland and Estonia. Several international artistes will perform in India for the first time. , in an edition shaped by two decades of exchanges, friendships and collaborations.

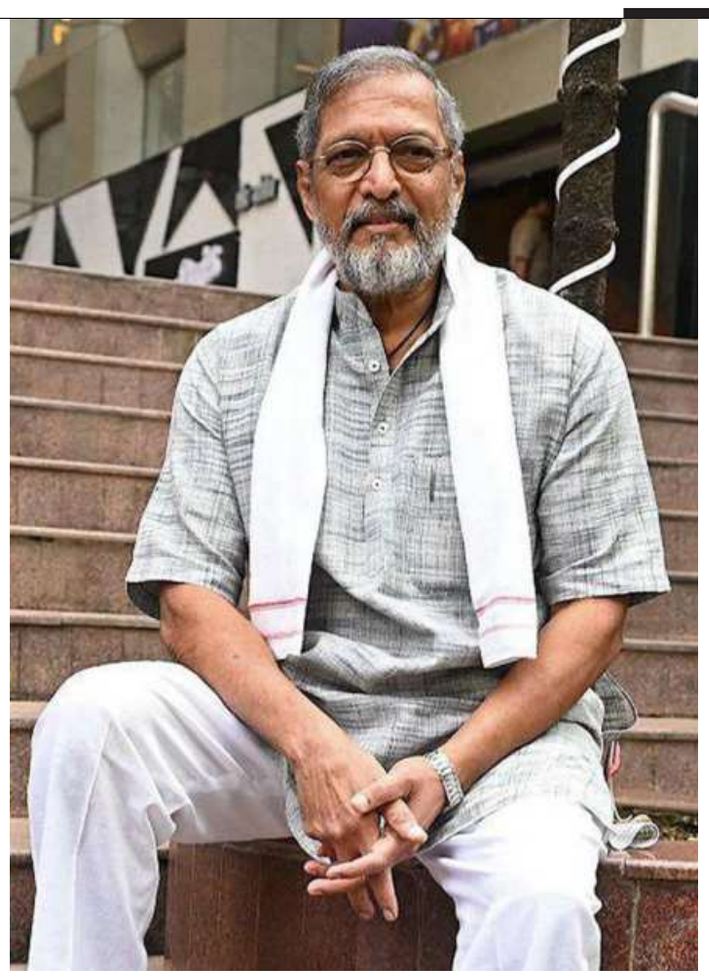
Rajasthan's folk musicians remain at the heart of Jodhpur RIFF. More than 250 artistes from communities including the Manganiyar, Langa, Meghwal, Bhopa, Kalbelia, Meena and Bhil traditions will perform. The 2026 edition features Indian masters and contemporary performers such as vocalist Ashwini Bhide-Deshpande, pena player Mangka Mayanglambam, pianist-composer Merlin D'Souza, vocalist Jasleen Kaur Monga and violinist Ambi Subramaniam. Filipino-Murrawari artist DOBBY, Latin American duo Camila y Silvio, British flute and Uilleann pipe player Michael McGoldrick, and Guitare Voginha of Cabo Verde are among the international artistes making their India debut. The festival also presents The Book of Queens, alongside performances by Martha Redbone and Aaron Whitby.

Collaborations form the crux of the edition, with young Langa trio SAZ performing with Michael McGoldrick and Donald Shaw, while Martha Redbone develops a new partnership with SAZ. With concerts unfolding across Mehrangarh's courtyards and surrounding spaces, the fort once again becomes a meeting place for roots music from Rajasthan, India and the world. Events will be staged at Jaswant Thada, Zenana Courtyard, Rao Jodha Desert Rock Park, Club Mehran, Veer Durga Das Memorial Park and Chokelao Bagh.



"Jodhpur RIFF has given Rajasthani folk artists a mainstream presence and a national and international platform. It is now the calling card for Rajasthani folk music, with each edition featuring around 200 musicians, dancers and performers from the state.

"The festival has brought artists respect and recognition, introducing both exemplary and unknown performers to audiences. We believe traditions survive through sharing and learning, which is why we consistently create collaborations featuring these artists and take them to prestigious venues across India and overseas. RIFF has also developed more new work with traditional musicians than any other entity. The press, invited to witness these performances, has written more about their music, names, stories and communities in the past decade than in the last 50 years. RIFF has made Rajasthani folk artists household names, leading to greater employment in mainstream society and positively impacting their livelihoods," says Divya Bhatia, director and curator of the festival.



A *dialogue* with music

When the arc lights dimmed, actor Nana Patekar retreated into a world of ragas and poetry

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As an invitee on Indian Idol a year ago, Nana Patekar sat immersed in music as contestant Sneha Shankar sang 'Ye dil tum bin kahin lagta nahin' (from the film *Izzat*), punctuating her rendition with appreciative "wah wahs". When she finished, he stood up and asked if she knew the next *antara*, beginning with 'Mohabbat kar to le lekin...'. As she sang, he stood listening, savouring every nuance. Many actors appear on reality shows as guest judges, often as part of film promotions. Nana's presence, however, felt different. He brought an unfeigned love for music and an artiste's curiosity to the proceedings. His engagement with the contestants was genuine, marked by the same sincerity and spontaneity that characterised him wherever he went. It was also a glimpse into a lesser-known side of Nana Patekar.

Singer Subashree Debnath recalled a similarly memorable encounter on the Sa Re Ga Ma show, when he requested her to sing 'Jaane kya baat hai', the Lata Mangeshkar classic. "That beautiful interaction, his warmth, presence and love for music created a memory I will carry forever," she wrote in a Facebook post. On yet another music reality show, the actor surprised contestants by taking his place at the tabla and inviting a singer to perform alongside him.

These moments revealed an artiste who valued the interconnectedness of the arts. At a time, when artistic practices often operate in silos, Nana Patekar recognised how one form enriched another. That understanding, perhaps, is what set him apart as an artiste.

The world celebrated Nana Patekar for his exceptional acting on screen and stage, but he was equally a passionate *rasik* of Indian classical and folk music. Just three days before his passing, he was seen playing the ghumot, Goa's traditional percussion instrument, at a cultural event in Panaji, a poignant reminder of a lifelong engagement with the arts.

I witnessed this firsthand at a concert by senior Hindustani vocalist Kalapini Komkali at Mumbai's National Centre for the Performing Arts. An ardent admirer of her father, Pt Kumar Gandharva, Nana sat through the concert in rapt attention. Before leaving, he spoke to a few fellow attendees about the Kumar Gandharva compositions he especially cherished.

Says Shashi Vyas, Mumbai-based cultural curator and founder of the music organisation Pancham Nishad: "He was a regular at the Chintamani Jayanti Samaroh, which I organised in memory of my father, the renowned vocalist and composer Pt. C.R. Vyas. Whenever he was unable to attend, he would invariably call to say how much he would miss the event. What was remarkable was the breadth of his listening. He admired stalwarts such as Begum Akhtar, Bal Gandharva, Ustad Bade Ghulam Ali Khan, Ustad Vilayat Khan, Pt. Bhimsen Joshi and Kishori Amonkar, and also followed Carnatic music, fondly listening in recent years to musicians such as T.M. Krishna."

Nana would often hold intimate baithaks at his Pune home and host some of his favourite musicians for lunch or dinner, among them was Ustad Rashid Khan. "These gatherings reflected not just his love for music but also his desire to be in the company of musicians, interact with them and draw inspiration from their artistry. For Nana, music was not a pastime but an enduring passion that shaped many of his friendships," says Shashi.

In interviews over the years, Nana Patekar has often spoken about how classical music helps calm him and shut out the chaos around him. Trained in commercial art at the Sir J.J. Institute of Applied Art in Mumbai, he strongly believed that creative minds could heal a fractured world.

"Two months ago, he called me from the gym and said, 'I can't get over your raag Bagesri. *Kya bajaya hai!*' (How beautifully you have played). Before ending the call, he advised me to stay true to my legacy and not get carried away by gimmicks," recalls sitarist Shakir Khan, son of sitar maestro Ustad Shahid Parvez and a young musician to watch out for.

"He loved *abba's* (Ustad Shahid Parvez) playing a great deal and rarely missed his performances. They shared a relationship built on mutual admiration and affection. So I have known him since my training days. You cannot imagine the intensity with which he absorbed music. Once, he came to the sitar workshop that I conducted in Pune and sat through the entire three-hour session. He first watched me guide the participants and then asked me to play raag Pilu. He remained engrossed until the last note," shares Shakir.

Nana's bond with Indian classical music is said to have begun when he first heard the inimitable Gangubai Hangal and was moved by the emotional depth of her singing. He thereafter made it a point to attend her concerts in Mumbai and Pune, becoming a familiar presence at the Sawai Gandharva Sangeet Mahotsav, to listen to her and other greats of Hindustani music.

The iconic Marathi musical *Katyar Kaljat Ghusli*, a story of rivalry between two gharanas with a memorable score by Pt. Jitendra Abhisheki, is said to have kindled Nana Patekar's interest in Natyasangeet, Maharashtra's rich tradition of musical theatre. The production starred the legendary vocalist Pt Vasantrao Deshpande and continues to be celebrated for its songs. Years later, when Pt Deshpande's grandson, singer Rahul Deshpande, revived the play, Nana became one of its strongest supporters. He went on to serve as a patron and trustee of the Dr Vasantrao Deshpande Pratishthan and helped organise Vasantotsav, Pune's annual three-day classical music festival.

Beyond his deep engagement with music, Nana Patekar also had a way with words. He wrote poems that reflected on love, compassion and social inequities, often reciting them in his gravelly baritone at public events. The Marathi album *Nanachhand*, released in 2024, featured verses penned by him.

When the auditorium darkened and the camera stopped rolling, actor Nana Patekar returned to a life beyond the arc lights, one enriched by music, poetry and artistic camaraderie. He turned his home into a space where art found its simplest yet most profound expression.



Beat of belonging For Nana Patekar, the arts were never separate worlds but part of a larger creative conversation. PHOTOS: AFP & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Stage of the future

Twenty-four years after it opened with artistes –Ustad Rashid Khan, vidushi Ashwini Bhide Deshpande and Pt. Satish Vyas – 'Vartamaan – The Present' returns to Pune. Presented by GRACE Foundation and an initiative of Pancham Nishad, the two-day Hindustani classical series, will be held at Mumbai's Yashwantrao Chavan Natyagruha on October 17 (5 p.m.) and 18 (10 a.m.). It will present four young vocalists — Tejaswini Vernekar, an All India Radio 'A' grade artiste and Banaras Hindu University gold medallist; Siddhartha Belmannu, who trained under Pt. Vinayak Torvi; Mugdha Vaishampayan, trained in the Jaipur-Atrauli tradition and Aniruddh Aithal, a disciple of Ashok Huggannavar. Tickets on BookMyShow.

A Kuchipudi retreat

Srividya Angara Sinha, founder of Citsabhā Centre for Kuchipudi and Allied Arts, presents NISHTHA 2026, a three-day residential Kuchipudi intensive at Ritambhara Retreat, Bengaluru. To be held from today to October 18, it is curated and conducted by the Bengaluru-based dancer and choreographer Srividya. "NISHTHA is designed to strengthen and condition the dancer's body while working through the vast grammar of Kuchipudi, supported by allied paradigms like yoga," she says. This intensive will focus on foundational and advanced technique, theory, abhinaya and mindful practice. It is open to learners with at least six to eight months of training. To register, call 8197241721.







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